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UAE CARRIERS DEFY REGIONAL SLUMP

Emirates operates 100 flights; 23,000 flights in region cancelled

DUBAI
BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

UAE airlines began cautiously restoring operations yesterday, even as more than 23,000 flights, according to Cirium, have been cancelled across the Middle East since airspace closures began. Carriers in Dubai and Abu Dhabi are operating reduced or limited services, while airports are restricting access to confirmed passengers only.

Across the wider region, airlines are organising relief, repatriation and charter flights as partial airspace reopenings allow a gradual return to the skies. According to the aviation analytics company, 15 flights departed from Abu Dhabi, 87 from Dubai, and 60 from Muscat, Oman on March 5.

Emirates confirmed it is operating a reduced schedule until further notice. Through yesterday and today, more than 100 flights will depart from and return to Dubai, carrying passengers and essential cargo, including perishables and pharmaceuticals. The airline said it will gradually rebuild operations subject to airspace availability and operational approvals. Customers have been advised to travel only with a confirmed booking.

flydubai has resumed services across its network with a reduced schedule. Flight times may be longer due to rerouting. Passengers must not travel without confirmed bookings.

Etihad Airways said scheduled commercial flights to and



Dubai Airports

■ Carriers in Dubai and Abu Dhabi are operating reduced or limited services, while airports are restricting access to confirmed passengers only.

from Abu Dhabi remain suspended until 6am UAE time on March 6. Limited repositioning, cargo and repatriation flights are operating with approvals.

Air Arabia said UAE flights remain suspended until 3pm on March 9, with limited approved services operating.

Airport advisories

Dubai Airports said most flights remain suspended and urged passengers not to come to the airport without confirmed departures. Abu Dhabi's

Zayed International Airport has resumed limited operations in coordination with authorities.

Sharjah International Airport is restricting entry to confirmed passengers only.

Regional halt

Airspace closures across Iran, Israel, Iraq, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait and Syria have halted regular commercial traffic across much of the region. Partial restrictions remain in the UAE and Saudi Arabia.

Qatar Airways has suspend-

ed operations due to the closure of Qatari airspace, but planned limited relief flights from yesterday from Muscat and Riyadh to select European cities. Gulf Air said it repatriated more than 400 transit passengers and will resume normal operations once conditions permit.

Oman Air cancelled multiple regional routes through March 8 but is adding extra long-haul services to cities including London Heathrow, Istanbul and Bangkok.

According to aviation ana-

SCHOOL ADVISORIES

Indian schools and other schools in Dubai, whose academic year begins in April, will complete the current term through distance learning, the Knowledge and Human Development Authority (KHDA) clarified yesterday.

The announcement was conveyed to schools in a circular following the decision by the Ministry of Education to advance the spring break by one week. KHDA also said that CBSE/ICSE and schools whose academic year begins in April will resume 2026-2027 academic year on Monday, April 6, 2026.

However, the Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA) yesterday announced the postponement of the start of the next academic year for Indian and Pakistani schools in the emirate.

— Sajila Saseendran,
Chief Reporter
SEE ALSO P2



IFTAR 18:27

Fajr	05:20	Shuruq	06:34
Jum'a	12:33	Asr	15:53
Maghrib	18:27	Isha	19:40

IMSAK 05:10

Add 4 minutes for Abu Dhabi, deduct 4 minutes for RAK and 6 minutes for Fujairah



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EU, Gulf states demand Iran halt attacks that risk global security

Italy to send air-defence aid as Europe ramps up response

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

European Union and Gulf ministers yesterday urged Iran to immediately halt attacks across the region, warning that the escalating conflict risks undermining global security as the war in the Middle East entered its sixth day.

Foreign ministers from the European Union and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) — UAE, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait and Oman — held emergency talks by video link as Iranian missiles and drones continued targeting Gulf cities and infrastructure in retaliation for US-Israeli strikes.

"The ministers strongly condemned the unjustifiable Iranian attacks against the GCC countries which threaten regional and global security and called on Iran to cease immediately its attacks," a joint statement said. They also



AFP

■ Israel bombs a solar farm and electricity generation facility in Lebanon.

affirmed the right of Gulf states to take "all necessary measures" to defend themselves.

European countries are also moving military assets into the region. British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said four fighter jets would be sent to Qatar to strengthen defensive operations, while military helicopters equipped with counter-drone capabilities are due to arrive in Cyprus. Italy said it would send air-defence assistance to Gulf nations facing Iranian strikes, with Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni saying the move would help protect thousands of Italian civilians and troops in the region.

European leaders stressed the deployments were aimed at protecting their citizens, interests

and key shipping routes rather than joining offensive operations.

Beyond Middle East

The conflict is increasingly spilling beyond the Middle East. Azerbaijan said two Iranian drones landed in the Nakhchivan exclave on its border with Iran, though Tehran denied launching them and blamed Israel. Iran also rejected Turkey's claim that it fired a missile toward Turkish airspace earlier this week.

Fighting continued across multiple fronts. The US military said it was "finding and destroying" Iran's mobile missile launchers, while Iran struck Kurdish opposition groups in northern Iraq. Across the Gulf, Bahrain said it intercepted 75 Iranian ballistic missiles and 124 drones during the latest barrage.

Israel launched new strikes against Hezbollah positions, with Israeli forces ordering residents of Beirut's southern suburbs to evacuate immediately.

Meanwhile, Iran has imposed a near-total internet blackout, with monitoring group Net-Blocks saying connectivity has dropped to about one per cent of normal levels.

SEE ALSO P5-11

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